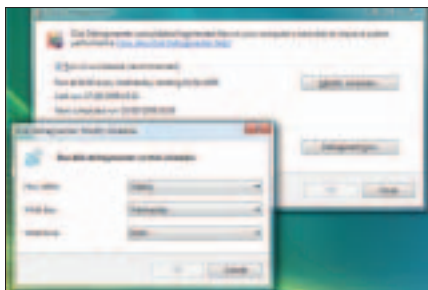


drive to clean up and, once you click OK, it will perform an initial scan on the drive. When this completes, you'll be shown sections of your hard disk that Vista believes can be deleted to free up space. Clicking on each section provides you with more information on the type of files located within. Simply check those selections you want to delete and click OK.

Defrag your drive

Another way to improve performance is to run Disk Defragmenter regularly. To locate the tool, head to the Start menu and type defrag into the search box. The defrag process goes through your hard disk, grouping elements that have become scattered over time. Depending on the size of your hard disk,



Disk Defragmenter keeps your hard disk running smoothly – set it to run regularly

the defrag process can take a considerable amount of time and is something we'd recommend running at night. A good way to ensure that your hard disk is always running efficiently is to set a regular defrag schedule. To do this, click Modify Schedule and then choose a time and frequency. Alternatively, click Defrag Now to start the process immediately.

Working with Control Panel

Whether you're changing the look of Vista, adding a new user account or altering the power settings, Control Panel is a good place to start since it houses a wide range of tools within a single window. It therefore makes sense to spend some time getting to know how it works and customising it to suit your needs. You'll also discover how to create shortcuts to the most popular items within it.

One of the most well-received components of Vista is its enhanced search tool. In Windows XP, file searches were painfully slow: the hard disk would whirr away for a good five minutes or even longer before returning often irrelevant results.

In Vista, not only are searches almost instantaneous, but you

can also hunt down emails, documents and other files based on their contents. We also explain how to use logical search terms such as AND and NOT, along with how to save your favourite searches for future use.



The Control Panel is where you'll find most of Vista's tools for customising your Windows experience

Take Vista to task

By default, Vista's Taskbar sits along the bottom of your screen. It houses the Start button, quick-launch icons and buttons for running applications, along with notification icons for services such as MSN Messenger and your security software.

To customise how this looks and operates, right-click the Start button and select Properties. You'll now see a range of options, including tabs for the Taskbar, Start



Vista Ultimate owners can download special applications, add-ons and games directly from Microsoft

Menu, Notification Area and Toolbars. Click on the Customize button within the Start Menu tab and you'll find a host of options to play with. You'll be pleased to hear you can't damage your PC by changing any of these options, although it's a good idea to create a System Restore point first or make a note of those options you change.

More options are available under the other three tabs. The Notification Area section allows you to adjust settings, such as specifying which icons should be hidden (either when inactive or all the time), while the Taskbar tab provides access to features including turning off grouping for similar Taskbar buttons and hiding the Taskbar from view when not in use. By unchecking the Lock the Taskbar option, you can change the size of the Taskbar as well as move it to a different position on your screen.